CUTTIT · SKILL 01 · THE COMPLETE GUIDE

Byline

How to turn any talking-head video into a premium editorial reel with Claude: setup, your first edit, every option, and how this skill was built.





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> **What's in your download:** `byline/SKILL.md` (the skill), `byline/style.json` (the exact style values), `byline/scripts/` (the tested renderer), `byline/scripts/plan.example.json` (the demo's edit plan), and this guide.

2 · WHAT YOU NEED

- **A computer** (Mac, Windows or Linux; phones can't render) with **Claude Code**: the Claude desktop app's Code tab or the VS Code extension, on a paid Claude plan.
- **Python 3.10+** and **ffmpeg**. Both are free; Claude installs the Python packages for you.
- **Your talking-head video:** 1080p or better, 15–90 seconds works best.
- **Time:** a quick preview takes about 3 minutes; the final 60 fps render takes about 2 minutes per second of video.

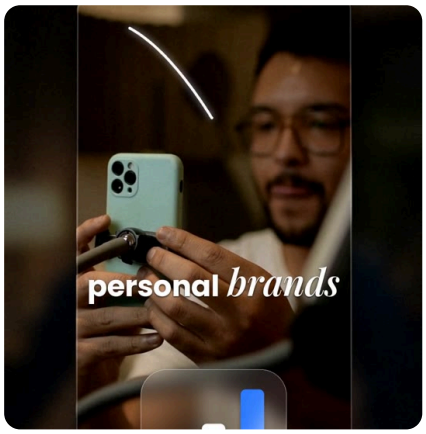
1 · WHAT BYLINE DOES

A premium edit, *designed for your script*

Byline is a **Claude skill**: a folder of instructions plus tested code that you add to Claude Code once. After that, you send Claude a talking-head video and say *"Edit this video with Byline."* Claude transcribes it, reads your script, designs an edit for it, and renders a finished 1080×1920 reel.



Text behind you



B-roll as a 3D card



Orbit line + giant number

ELEMENT	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Pop-in captions	1–2 words at a time in Poppins Bold, popping 80→100% and hard-cutting; key words switch to a big Playfair Italic serif.
Text behind you	Giant words rise letter by letter *behind* your head. Claude cuts you out on every frame with an AI matte.
Lines	Glowing strokes that draw themselves: an orbit looping behind your neck, swooshes that lead b-roll in.
Breaker cards	Full-screen black or white word cards whose letters build one by one, synced to a bass whoosh.
Motion graphics	Bar charts, padlocks, hearts, counters, calendars and icon chips on frosted glass, floating and shimmering.
B-roll	Floating 3D cards over a blurred you, iris reveals, or full screen, in slow motion.
Feel	60 fps, smooth intentional camera moves, soft white light-flash transitions, synced sound effects, a quiet music bed.

3 · SETUP (ONCE, ABOUT 10 MINUTES)

Set up Byline

1. **Install Claude Code.** Download the Claude desktop app from `claude.ai/download` and sign in, then open the **Code** tab. (Or install the Claude Code extension in VS Code.)

2. **Install ffmpeg and Python.**

```
Mac (Terminal):
  brew install ffmpeg python

Windows (PowerShell):
  winget install Gyan.FFmpeg
  winget install Python.Python.3.12
  (close and reopen PowerShell afterwards)
```

3. **Install the skill.** Unzip `byline-skill.zip`. Move the `byline` folder into your Claude skills folder:

```
Mac / Linux:  ~/.claude/skills/byline/
Windows:      C:\Users\<you>\.claude\skills\byline\
```

   You should now have `.../skills/byline/SKILL.md`.

4. **Make a project folder** for your reels, e.g. `Documents/reels`, and open it in Claude Code.

5. **Let Claude finish the setup.** Paste this:

```
Set up Byline in this folder: install the Python packages from the Byline skill,
download the two fonts (Poppins Bold, Playfair Display Italic) into fonts/,
and download the MODNet model into models/modnet.onnx as the skill says.
Then confirm everything works.
```

> **Check:** ask Claude *"Is Byline ready?"*. It should confirm ffmpeg, Python packages, fonts and the model.

4 · YOUR FIRST EDIT

From raw clip to *Byline*

1. **Drop your video** into the project folder (e.g. `myvideo.mp4`).
2. **Ask:** `Edit myvideo.mp4 with Byline.`
3. **Choose how to work.** Claude asks: *A) Customise* (fonts, colours, music, ending…) or *B) Leave it to me*. For your first edit, choose B.
4. **Check the transcript.** Fix any misspelled names.
5. **Approve the edit plan.** Claude lists every moment: time, line, effect, sound. Example from the demo:

LINE	EFFECT	SOUND
"I've audited…"	"AUDITED" rises behind the speaker, camera dollies in	flash whoosh
"top tier personal brands"	Creator b-roll as a 3D card + bar chart on glass	pop
"their biggest secret"	Iris reveal of b-roll, padlock clicks shut	pop, click
"nothing … viral"	Kinetic black and white breaker cards	deep whoosh ×2
"Nobody cares… grid"	Black-and-white, "NOBODY" behind, heart "0", grid + red line	pop, wrong
"exactly one"	Orbit line behind the neck, giant serif "1" behind the shoulder	shine
"strategy session with me"	Massive "SESSION" CTA over a b-roll card, calendar check	impact, click

6. **Watch the preview** (fast, 30 fps). Say what to change.
7. **Get the final reel** at 60 fps, then give notes one round at a time: *"the 1 is too big"*, *"less music"*, *"swap the heart for a counter"*.

5 · CUSTOMISE

The 10 options

Choose **A) Customise** and Claude asks these in one message. Answer only what you care about, or reply "defaults".

OPTION	DEFAULT	YOU CAN…
1. Video	-	Send any talking-head clip
2. Fonts	Poppins Bold + Playfair Display Italic	Use your brand fonts
3. Colours	Blue = good, red = wrong	Use your brand colour
4. Music	A calm original bed, very low	Send your own track, or none
5. Sound effects	Generated by Byline	Use your own SFX pack (folder)
6. Ending	Your own CTA, or none	"comment WORD" with a massive keyword
7. Energy	Standard	Calm (fewer effects) or Hype (more, faster)
8. B-roll	A shot list with free links	Send your own clips
9. Language	Spoken language	Names and words to spell exactly
10. Handle	None	@yourname at the end

> Your answers override the style; everything else stays Byline. Claude summarises your choices in one line before it starts.

Why no two Byline edits *look the same*

Byline isn't a template. Claude tags every sentence with a **beat**, then picks one effect per beat by meaning:

BEAT	EFFECTS CLAUDE CHOOSES FROM
Hook	Giant word behind you + dolly-in · kinetic breaker card
Secret	Padlock that clicks shut · iris reveal
Myth / wrong	Black-and-white section · red strike or red X
List / apps	Icon chips (play, pin, check, heart)
Number	Giant serif number behind you · counter · ring + burst
Growth	Bar chart building itself · counter
Comparison	Red vs blue boxes · split-screen b-roll
Emotion	Heart with a number
Time / booking	Calendar with a check
Connecting ideas	Swoosh lines · orbit line behind your neck
Proof	B-roll as a 3D card · iris reveal · full screen
Call to action	Massive serif keyword, instructions cycling underneath

The composition rules

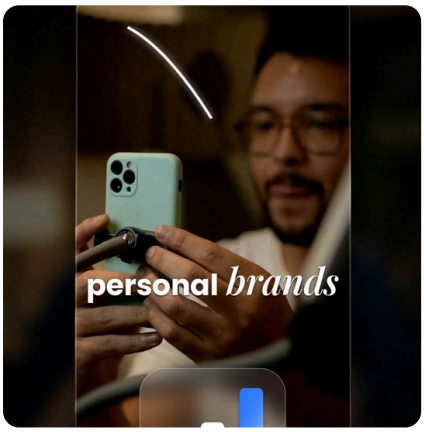
- **One hero moment** per video: the biggest effect, on your hook or strongest line.
- **Never the same effect twice in a row**; b-roll treatments and card colours rotate.
- **Something changes every 1.5–3 s**, with at most one graphic on screen besides the caption, plus calm stretches so the big moments land.
- **Nothing over your face.** If the library doesn't fit, Claude **designs a new element** in the same style and explains it in the plan.

7 · B-ROLL, SOUND EFFECTS AND MUSIC

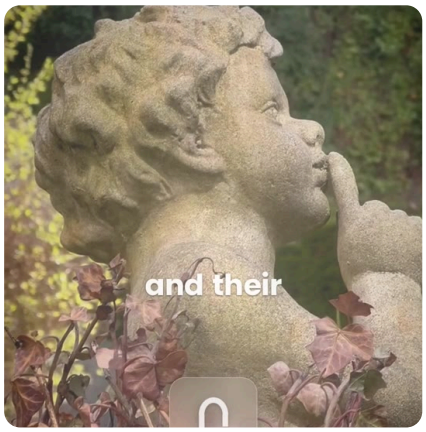
Make it richer

B-roll

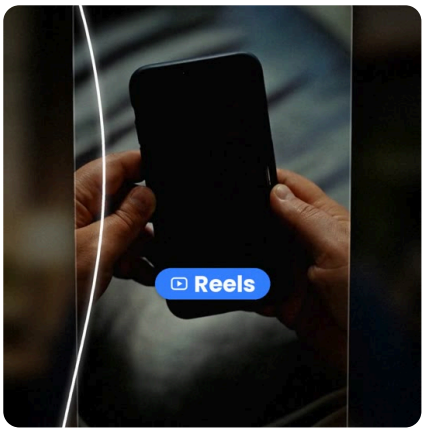
1. Ask: `Give me a b-roll shot list for this video.` Claude lists one shot per moment, with free Pexels search links (vertical clips) and an AI-video prompt alternative.
2. Download 1–2 clips per line (Full HD) and put them in a `broll` folder in your project, named by number: `1_analytics.mp4`.
3. Say: `Use the clips in broll.` Claude turns them into floating 3D cards, iris reveals or full-screen slow motion.



3D card from the right



Iris reveal, full screen



Card from the bottom + chips

Sound effects

Byline generates its own whooshes, pops, clicks and hits, which you're free to use. To use your own pack, put it in a `sfx_pack` folder and say `Use my SFX pack.` Claude maps your files to roles: deep whoosh (cards), flash whoosh (transitions), pop/click (UI), wrong, impact, shine, count.

Music

A calm original bed plays very low and ducks under your voice. Send your own track (e.g. from the YouTube Audio Library) or say "no music". Never use copyrighted songs you don't have rights to.

8 · RECORD FOR THE BEST RESULT

Feed Byline a good clip

- **1080p or 4K**, vertical (9:16) if possible.
- **Chest-up framing** with some space above your head, for text behind you.
- **Even light** on your face; a simple background.
- **Clear audio:** a clip-on mic beats the camera mic.
- **A strong first line**: Byline turns it into the hook.
- **15–60 seconds**, one idea per video.

9 · PROMPT CHEAT SHEET

Copy, paste, edit

YOU WANT	SAY
A full edit	`Edit myvideo.mp4 with Byline.`
Your style	`Edit it with Byline. Customise.`
Calmer / louder	`Make it Calm.` · `Make it Hype.`
A b-roll list	`Give me a b-roll shot list with Pexels links.`
A quick look	`Render a fast preview first.`
A different hero	`Make the hero moment the number, behind me.`
Swap an effect	`Replace the heart with a counter at 0:05.`
A CTA	`End with "comment GUIDE".`
A before/after	`Make a before/after reel: raw clip, white flash, Byline edit.`
Captions only	`Only the captions and power words, no graphics.`

10 · TROUBLESHOOTING

If something goes wrong

PROBLEM	FIX
"ffmpeg not found"	Install ffmpeg (section 3), then close and reopen the terminal or Claude Code.
Speech model download fails ("xet" error)	Tell Claude: `Set HF_HUB_DISABLE_XET=1 and retry.`
"CascadeClassifier" error	OpenCV 5 is installed. Tell Claude: `Install opencv-python-headless<5.`
Render is very slow	Normal at 60 fps. Use `Render a fast preview first` to check placement, then render the final.
Text covers my face	Tell Claude the time: `At 0:03 the caption covers my face, move it lower.`
Text behind me is hidden	`Move the text behind me higher`, or shorten it to one word.
AI watermark gets cropped	`Keep the watermark visible.` Byline anchors zooms on it.
Sound too loud / quiet	`Lower the whooshes` · `Music quieter` · `No SFX`.
Wrong word in captions	`At 0:04 it says X, it should be Y.`

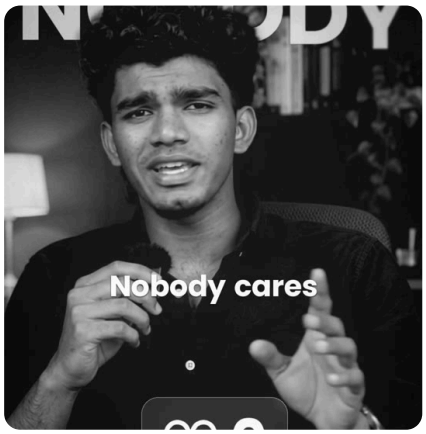
From one reference reel to *a product*

Everything in Byline, from the skill and the renderer to the tests, product page, share images, store copy and this guide, was made by working with Claude. This is the process, so you can use it for your own products.

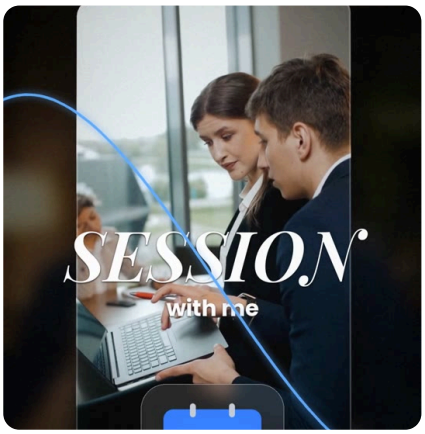
1. **Pick a reference.** I chose a premium editorial reel I loved and saved it.
2. **Break it down.** Claude studied it frame by frame (contact sheets, cut detection, colour and brightness curves) and measured the sound (onsets, spectrogram). I also asked Gemini to watch and listen, then Claude checked Gemini's notes against its measurements and corrected the mistakes.
3. **Turn it into rules.** The style became a fixed "DNA" (fonts, colours, motion, sound) plus a creative engine that picks effects per beat.
4. **Make it real code.** Claude wrote and tested a renderer (Python, ffmpeg, OpenCV, Whisper for captions, MODNet to cut out the speaker) on a 10-second AI clip.
5. **Iterate honestly.** Nine versions. Each round I said what I didn't like ("not smooth", "add motion graphics", "white flash, not glitch") and Claude rebuilt it: 60 fps interpolation, 3D b-roll cards, text behind the speaker, orbit lines.
6. **Package and sell.** Claude wrote the product page, share images, store copy and this guide. Claude in Chrome set up the store, using a handoff page written by the build chat.



Version 0: the raw clip



Version 9: depth, graphics, B&W



Version 9: CTA over a 3D card

Questions

Do I need editing experience?

No. You talk to Claude in plain language; the skill tells Claude exactly how to edit.

Will every video look the same?

No. Byline reads your script and picks different effects for different beats, with one hero moment per video.

Can I use my own fonts, colours, music and sound effects?

Yes. Choose "Customise" and answer the questions you care about.

Can I use it on my phone?

No. Rendering needs a computer with Claude Code.

Can I use the reels for clients?

Yes. The reels you make are yours to post or sell.

What about stock footage and music?

Use clips and tracks you have the rights to. Pexels clips are free to use in videos; don't redistribute the clips themselves. Byline's generated sound effects and music bed are yours to use.

Licence. Your purchase lets you use Byline for your own and your clients' videos. Please don't share, resell or publish the skill files (SKILL.md, style.json, scripts) or this guide. Fonts: Poppins and Playfair Display (SIL Open Font License). Cut-out model: MODNet (Apache-2.0). Not affiliated with Anthropic; Claude is a trademark of Anthropic.

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